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Stewardship land reclassification leaves high-value ecological areas without top-tier protection

11 December 2025

The Environmental Defence Society (EDS) congratulates the Minister of Conservation, Hon Tama Potaka, for finally making decisions on the reclassification of Western South Island stewardship land.

“To get an outcome is a significant step and it’s a credit to Minister Potaka that he has got this over the line in what is a challenging coalition government,” says Shay Schlaepfer EDS COO.

“Stewardship land contains vast tracts of high-value forests, river systems and plateau ecosystems, including large land parcels within the Te Wāhipounamu–South West New Zealand World Heritage Area, the ecologically significant Denniston Plateau and large areas adjacent to existing national parks with contiguous values.

“The Minister’s decisions reclassify 314 parcels of stewardship land into higher conservation status categories, retain 191 parcels as stewardship land and dispose of 63 parcels.

"While the decisions deliver conservation gains, it is disappointing that only 6 parcels are being referred to the New Zealand Conservation Authority for consideration as National Park.

"This is a significant reduction on the 48 parcels recommended for National Park by the Department of Conservation.

"EDS made a substantive submission on the reclassification proposals, informed by independent expert ecological evidence. Much of our analysis favoured upgrades to higher protective status including to National Park and Scientific Reserve. That included large land parcels adjoining existing National Parks, where the ecological values are contiguous.

"The Minister has instead favoured Conservation Park and Historic Reserve status. That is concerning because those categories are not included in Schedule 4 of the Crown Minerals Act. Only land listed in Schedule 4 of that Act, such as National Parks and Scientific Reserves, are safeguarded from mining activities.

"EDS will now undertake a parcel-by-parcel assessment of the Minister's decisions, comparing them to both the statutory tests and the ecological evidence.

"If the decision-making process has been incorrectly constrained, or if irrelevant considerations have crept in, such as potential economic uses of the land or fast-track development opportunities, that would be unlawful. Stewardship land reclassification must be driven by the clear conservation purposes set out in the Conservation Act.

"Given the wide interest and importance of these decisions for our natural world, they will face careful scrutiny by many parties, both procedurally and substantively. Legal challenges cannot be ruled out.

"Given what is at stake, from World Heritage areas to highly threatened ecosystems, the public deserves confidence that stewardship land is being classified properly, transparently and in accordance with the law.

"EDS will not hesitate to take steps necessary to ensure that outcome," concluded Ms Schlaepfer.

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